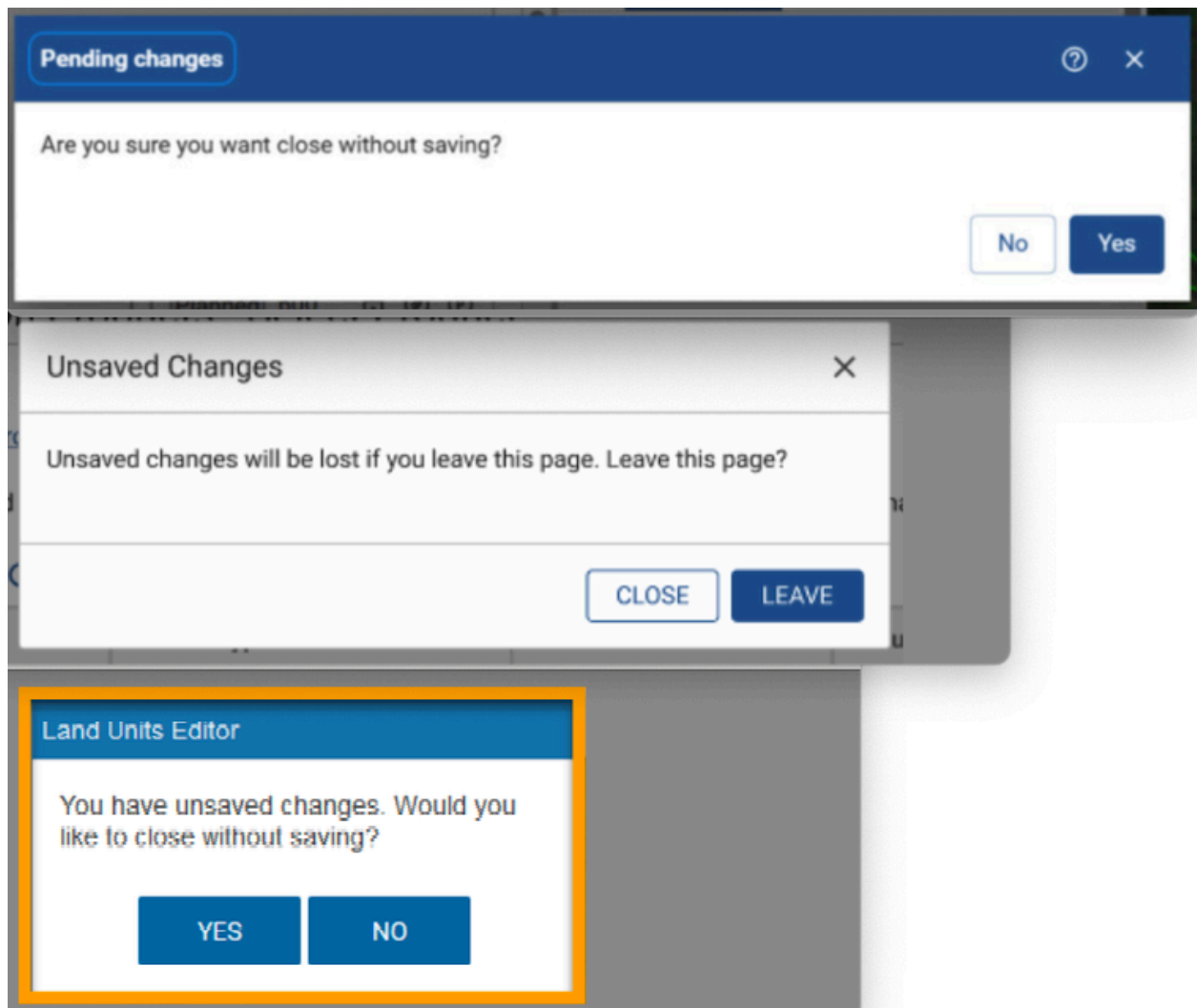


Unsaved Changes Modal – Before & After

Context

While working under the USDA-NRCS contract, I encountered multiple versions of an “Unsaved Changes” modal across different legacy applications. Over time, the lack of UI standards had led to wildly inconsistent user experiences. This caused confusion, increased cognitive load, and undermined trust.

Before: Inconsistent Modal Patterns

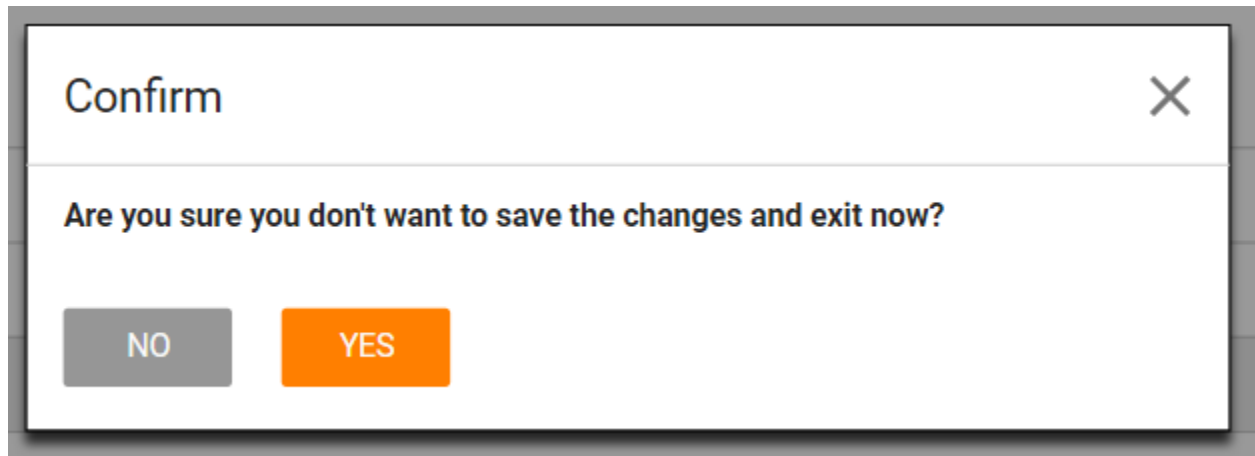


Users encountered variations like:

- **Titles:** Pending changes, Unsaved Changes, Land Units Editor
- **Messages:** Are you sure?, Unsaved changes will be lost, You have unsaved changes

- **Button Labels:** No, Yes, CLOSE, LEAVE
- **Button Order:** Sometimes Yes / No, other times No / Yes
- **Visual Design:** Some used **two primary buttons**, others mixed cases (Title Case, ALL CAPS, Sentence case)

One version was so unclear it sparked actual laughter from the team:



“No, I’m not sure I don’t want to...wait. What?”

After: A Clear, Consistent Pattern

We developed a consistent modal based on the following UX writing principles:

Title

- Use **title case**
- Prefer **verb phrases** (unless it could startle or confuse users)
- **Match** the title to the **primary action button**, where possible

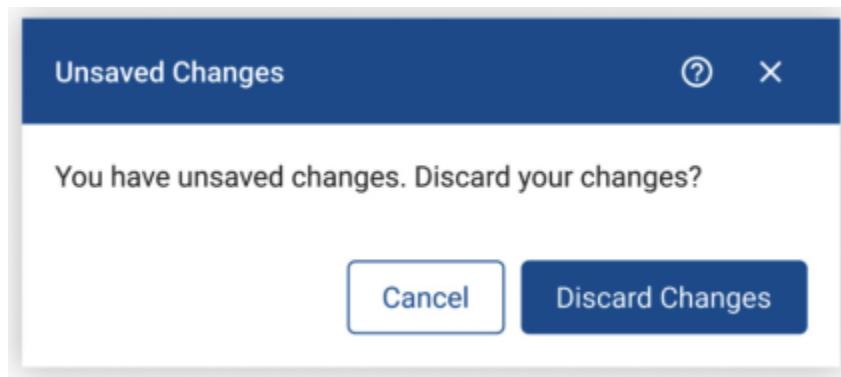
Message Body

- Keep it **short, clear**, and **front-loaded** with key info
- Use **positive framing**
- Write in the **second person**, unless it sounds condescending
- Include a **call to action** (CTA)

Buttons

- Always show **primary and secondary** buttons
- **Cancel** on the **left** (for screen reader convenience)
- Use **verb phrases** for primary button labels
- Match the **primary button label** to the **modal title**, where possible

Final Modal Design



Element	Content	Notes
Title	Unsaved Changes	Broke the “verb phrase” pattern to avoid alarming users
Message	You have unsaved changes. Discard your changes?	Repeats title to front-load key info and includes clear CTA
Buttons	Cancel (left), Discard Changes (right)	Matches standard placement and labeling, prioritized screen reader flow

Takeaway

This project shows how UX writing, even in a seemingly small element like a modal, can dramatically improve clarity and consistency. By identifying common inconsistencies, creating reusable patterns, and aligning with accessibility principles, I helped create a solution that respected users' time and reduced friction.